

FIELD OF VISION SHARDA UGRA

What's in a Name?



Hot airline, cool beer, but Vijay Mallya cannot be serious about the name he wants to give his new Formula 1 team. The name 'Force India' may sound all shiny, happy, global India to some but, in sporting terms, the team that Mallya now owns are, strictly speaking, backbenchers, woodenspooners, no-hopers.

There is no doubt a masterly business plan at work to turn the team, formerly known as Jordan/Midland/Spyker, into a dream brand in India and add the lustre of the Mallya empire. But, after early euphoria, what we, the bedazzled spectators, are really looking at, are headlines like: "*Force India struggle/Force India off the pace/Force India trail/Force India bomb.*"

No other F1 team has a nationality attached to its name; all are commercial enterprises and duly kowtow to their sponsors. Hanging 'India' on to his latest venture may be a move to invoke our surging patriotism but, once the racing begins, it can also fatally become a cue for national self-flagellation. See the thing is if Mallya called his team Force Kingfisher or Force Vijay or whatever, we would still root for it. Bringing India into this means only more gloomy headlines.

This may sound ultra-defeatist, but the truth is that in F1 the difference between the haves and the have-nots, over and above skill or will, is money. The balance between driving skill and the quality of the car in F1 is skewed heavily towards technology. Put drivers of the same ability in a Williams and a "Force India" and the Williams will always win.

Put it like this: even Michael Schumacher in top form would not be able to win the F1 world championships if he were in Mr Mallya's car.

If Force India wants to move up just one row on the grid, from last to second last—where teams like Super Aguri Honda and Toro Rosso lurk—experts reckon, Mallya would need to be spend around \$120 million more. To run a top competitive team needs a massive investment in top-quality engineers and designers and in fixed assets like wind tunnels, tracks, carbon fibre workshops. McLaren's budget this year was estimated to be in the region of \$400 million. BMW Sauber has at its service, Albert 2, Europe's fastest super computer used in the industry.

This is the world of big boys and expensive toys that Mallya has entered. He has every right to be there and to increase his brand visibility and overall profits, but could he please check the faux-patriotism at the door?



SAURABH SINGH

S. PRA DAS



Mollah

PURUSHOTTAM D WAKAR



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Language Capers

DELHI Rajasthan Chief Minister Vasundhara Raje's reported "anti-Bangladeshi" drive in her state has got her into trouble with the Marxists. "As all English-speaking people cannot be Englishmen, similarly, all Bangla-speaking people cannot be termed as Bangladeshis," wrote CPI(M) MP Hannan Mollah in a letter to Raje.

The eighth term Lok Sabha member from Uluberia in West Bengal has alleged that the Raje administration has been "harassing" Bangla-speaking people engaged in odd jobs in the state. According to Mollah, the state police has been "extorting" money from such workers who travelled from West Bengal to Rajasthan in the last few months. "Despite carrying proof of their Indian citizenship, they are being branded as illegal Bangladeshi migrants," he says.

In his letter, Mollah mentions two permanent residents—Jinnat Shaikh and Hazrat Ali—of West Bengal's Murshidabad district who had been sent to the Jaipur central jail as

"illegal Bangladeshis" although they had produced their school certificates, ration cards, voter identity cards and land revenue receipts before the police.

Anyone who speaks in Bangla and is a Muslim seems to be under suspicion in Rajasthan these days especially after the bomb blast in Ajmer. The CPI(M) leader has assured the BJP chief minister that while he would not object to Raje initiating action against "illegal Bangladeshi migrants", he would be disappointed if "the harassment of genuine Indians" did not stop. Raje has not replied to Mollah's letter yet.

The chief minister should perhaps look at West Bengal where Rajasthanis have been settled for years, enhancing their business under the patronage of Marxist leaders. Rajasthanis in West Bengal also cannot claim that the police does not help them, especially when Bangla-speaking Muslims need to be taught a lesson.

by Satarupa Bhattacharya